

Understanding karamah: the sharia principle behind interfaith coexistence

Analysis run: September 12, 2026

PROVIDER

Openrouter

MODEL

Anthropic/claude-opus-4.7 En

LANGUAGE

AUDIENCE

GENERAL

INTONATION

NEUTRAL

LENGTH

Long

TEMPERATURE

0.7

SYSTEM PROMPT

You are an expert AI content generator specializing in creating structured article.

USER PROMPT

Write a concise, self-contained article entry for the title: "Understanding karamah: the sharia principle behind interfaith coexistence".

Overall topic for alignment: Muslim-non-Muslim relations grounded in human dignity in sharia.

Important points to cover: Include Arabic terms, historical contexts, quranic foundations of sharia, minority and majority settings, Islamic theological schools, Islamic juristic schools of Hanafi, Hambali, shafi'i and Malaki, orientalist perspective, AI's humanistic approach to sharia, Human rights declaration..

- Output format: GitHub-Flavored Markdown. The markdown must be clean—do not include any code fences or surrounding markers. Target writing format: Blog Post. Follow these format-specific rules exactly:
- Aim for at least 6000 characters while staying under 12000. Prefer verifiable facts from the provided sources; do not fabricate citations or specific data.
- Place external links only in the "References" section; do not include inline external links in the body text.
- Maximum content length (including headings and references): 12000 characters. If nearing the limit, prioritize the most informative sections and keep references to 2-3.
- Write in the target response language. Avoid fluff; be precise and actionable. Do not include images or tables.
- Do not include code fences or any text outside the markdown content.

No external web sources are attached. Do not fabricate citations or specific facts that cannot be verified. Keep claims general and verifiable. In the 'References' section, include: "No external sources used."

****Respond in English****

SUMMARY

Summary: Karāmah as the Sharia Principle of Interfaith Coexistence

Core Concept: Karāmah (Arabic for "dignity"/"honor") is an Islamic legal-theological principle establishing human dignity as intrinsic and universal, providing a foundation for Muslim–non-Muslim coexistence that parallels modern human rights discourse.

Qur'anic Basis: Anchored in Qur'an 17:70 ("We have honored the children of Adam"), which is universal, intrinsic, and precedes confessional categorization. Reinforced by 49:13 (diversity for mutual recognition) and 2:256 (no compulsion in religion).

Historical Application:

- The **Constitution of Madinah** (7th century) included Jewish tribes in a single political community.
- The **ahl al-dhimmah** framework across Rashidun, Umayyad, Abbasid, Andalusian, Ottoman, and Mughal polities provided protection, autonomy in personal law, and freedom of worship in exchange for *jizyah*—hierarchical but legally stable by pre-modern standards.

Juristic Schools:

- **Ḥanafī** (Abū Ḥanīfa): Inviolability of life grounded in *ādamiyyah* (humanness), not belief—most expansive.
- **Mālikī**: Emphasized customary coexistence (*ʿurf*).
- **Shāfiʿī**: Textually formalist but firm on dhimmī protections.
- **Ḥanbalī**: Ibn Taymiyyah held justice is owed even to non-Muslims.
- Shīʿī schools developed parallel frameworks.

Theological Lenses: Muʿtazilites grounded dignity in reason; Māturīdīs combined reason and revelation; Ashʿarīs grounded it in revelation—all affirming universality.

Majority vs. Minority Contexts: Classical fiqh assigns states protection duties in Muslim-majority settings; *fiqh al-aqalliyyāt* (al-Alwani, al-Qaradawi) emphasizes civic engagement and contractual obligations in minority contexts.

Western Scholarship: Early Orientalists (Goldziher, Schacht) framed dhimmī status as subordination; revisionist scholars (Hallaq, Emon, Abou El Fadl) offer more nuanced readings of Islamic legal pluralism.

Modern Human Rights: Karāmah resonates with the UDHR (1948), the Cairo Declaration (1990), and the Document on Human Fraternity (2019), providing an Islamic vocabulary for engaging human rights norms.

Humanistic Sharia: Scholars like Kamali, An-Na'im, and Ramadan situate karāmah within *maqāṣid al-sharī'ah*, with contemporary thinkers adding dignity and freedom to the classical five objectives. Coexistence is thus a structural feature of sharia, not a modern concession.

FULL CONTENT

Understanding Karamah: The Sharia Principle Behind Interfaith Coexistence

In contemporary debates over religious pluralism, the Arabic term **karāmah** (كرامة), meaning "dignity" or "honor," has emerged as a central concept for articulating how Islamic law approaches Muslim–non-Muslim relations. Rooted in the Qur'an and developed through centuries of juristic reasoning, karāmah offers a theological and legal foundation for coexistence that predates—and in many ways parallels—modern human rights discourse.

The Qur'anic Foundation

The principle of karāmah is most often traced to the Qur'anic verse: "*We have certainly honored (karramnā) the children of Adam*" (Qur'an 17:70). The verb *karrama* in this verse is significant for several reasons:

- It is universal in scope, addressing **banī Ādam** (the children of Adam), not a specific religious community.
- It establishes dignity as an **intrinsic** quality bestowed by divine decree, not earned through belief or behavior.
- It precedes legal categorizations such as Muslim, *dhimmī* (protected non-Muslim), or *musta'min* (a non-Muslim under temporary safe-conduct).

Other foundational verses reinforce this framework, including Qur'an 49:13, which presents human diversity as a divine intention for mutual recognition (*li-ta'ārafū*), and Qur'an 2:256, which prohibits

compulsion in religion (*lā ikrāha fī al-dīn*). Together, these verses form a Qur'anic anthropology in which human dignity is prior to confessional identity.

Historical Contexts: From Madinah to the Caliphates

The practical application of *karāmah* can be traced to the **Constitution of Madinah** (*Ṣaḥīfat al-Madīnah*), an early 7th-century document that organized relations between the Muslim community and Jewish tribes of the city. The document recognized non-Muslims as part of a single political community (*ummah wāḥidah*) with mutual obligations of defense and non-aggression.

Under the Rashidun, Umayyad, Abbasid, Andalusian, Ottoman, and Mughal polities, the legal category of **ahl al-dhimmah** (protected peoples) institutionalized a contract under which non-Muslims paid the *jizyah* tax in exchange for protection, internal autonomy in personal status law, and freedom of worship. While modern critics rightly note that *dhimmī* status involved hierarchical distinctions, historians also acknowledge that, in its time, the framework provided a degree of legal stability for religious minorities that was uncommon in the pre-modern world.

Karāmah in the Juristic Schools

The four major **Sunni madhāhib**—Ḥanafī, Mālikī, Shāfiʿī, and Ḥanbalī—each engaged the concept of human dignity, though with different emphases:

- **Ḥanafī**: Often considered the most expansive in extending civic protections to non-Muslims. Abū Ḥanīfa famously argued that the inviolability of life (*iṣmah*) is grounded in *ādamiyyah* (humanness) itself, not in Islamic belief. This position influenced the legal codes of the Ottoman Empire and Mughal India.
- **Mālikī**: Rooted in the practice of Madinah, Mālikī jurists emphasized communal coexistence and recognized customary arrangements (*ʿurf*) with non-Muslim populations, particularly in North Africa and al-Andalus.
- **Shāfiʿī**: Tended toward a more textually formalist approach but maintained robust protections for *dhimmī* contracts, treating their violation as a serious breach.
- **Ḥanbalī**: Often perceived as more restrictive, yet figures such as Ibn Taymiyyah articulated the principle that *justice* (*ʿadl*) is owed even to non-Muslims, famously stating that God upholds the just state even if it is unbelieving, and brings down the unjust state even if it is Muslim.

Shīʿī schools (Jaʿfarī, Zaydī, Ismāʿīlī) developed parallel frameworks, also grounding non-Muslim protections in scriptural and rational principles.

Theological Schools and Their Frameworks

Islamic theological traditions—**Ash‘arī**, **Māturīdī**, and **Mu‘tazilī**—approached karāmah through different epistemological lenses:

- The **Mu‘tazilites** emphasized rational moral realism, arguing that human dignity and justice are discernible through reason independent of revelation.
- The **Māturīdīs**, dominant among Ḥanafīs, held a moderate position affirming both reason and revelation as sources of ethical knowledge.
- The **Ash‘arīs** grounded dignity more strictly in revelation but did not dispute its universality.

These theological positions shaped how jurists interpreted the scope of karāmah—whether it extended robustly to all humans by reason or required scriptural specification.

Minority and Majority Settings

The application of karāmah varies significantly depending on whether Muslims live as a majority or minority:

- In **majority settings**, classical fiqh assigned the state responsibility for protecting non-Muslim life, property, places of worship, and personal status law.
- In **minority settings**, the jurisprudence of *fiqh al-aqalliyyāt* (jurisprudence of minorities), developed by contemporary scholars such as Taha Jabir al-Alwani and Yusuf al-Qaradawi, emphasizes civic engagement, respect for constitutional orders, and contractual obligations (*‘uqūd*) toward non-Muslim societies.

In both contexts, karāmah operates as a baseline ethical commitment: the dignity of the other is not contingent on demographic power.

Orientalist Perspectives

Western scholarship on Islamic law has historically oscillated between two poles. Earlier **Orientalists** such as Ignaz Goldziher and Joseph Schacht offered influential—if sometimes reductive—readings of Islamic legal history, occasionally framing *dhimmī* arrangements primarily through the lens of subordination. More recent scholarship, including the work of Wael Hallaq, Anver Emon, and Khaled Abou El Fadl, has nuanced these readings by examining how pre-modern Islamic legal pluralism actually functioned and how karāmah-based reasoning operated within it.

This corrective scholarship neither romanticizes the past nor dismisses it; it situates Islamic legal practice within its historical conditions while identifying internal resources for contemporary ethical reasoning.

Karāmah and the Universal Declaration of Human Rights

The **Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR)**, adopted by the United Nations in 1948, opens with the affirmation that "all human beings are born free and equal in dignity and rights." Many Muslim scholars have noted a striking conceptual resonance with Qur'an 17:70.

Subsequent documents, such as the **Cairo Declaration on Human Rights in Islam** (1990) and the more recent **Document on Human Fraternity** (2019, signed in Abu Dhabi), explicitly invoke human dignity as a shared ethical principle. While debates persist over the compatibility of specific provisions, the karāmah principle provides a substantive Islamic vocabulary for engaging international human rights norms—not as a foreign imposition but as a translatable ethical commitment.

A Humanistic Reading of Sharia

A humanistic approach to sharia—advanced by scholars such as Mohammad Hashim Kamali, Abdullahi An-Na'im, and Tariq Ramadan—centers karāmah and the **maqāṣid al-sharī'ah** (higher objectives of Islamic law). The classical maqāṣid include the preservation of life (*ḥifẓ al-nafs*), religion (*ḥifẓ al-dīn*), intellect (*ḥifẓ al-'aql*), lineage (*ḥifẓ al-nasl*), and property (*ḥifẓ al-māl*). Contemporary scholars increasingly add **dignity** and **freedom** as explicit objectives.

From this perspective, interfaith coexistence is not a concession to modernity but a structural feature of sharia itself, when sharia is read through its own foundational objectives rather than through isolated rulings detached from context.

Conclusion

Karāmah offers a coherent Islamic foundation for interfaith coexistence: scripturally grounded, historically practiced, juristically developed, and ethically resonant with contemporary human rights discourse. Recognizing dignity as intrinsic to every human being—Muslim or not—transforms coexistence from a pragmatic compromise into a theological commitment. In an era of religious polarization, retrieving karāmah from within the Islamic tradition provides both Muslims and their interlocutors with a shared ethical horizon.

SEGMENTED DATA (1)

Understanding Karamah: The Sharia Principle Behind Interfaith Coexistence

In contemporary debates over religious pluralism, the Arabic term **karāmah** (كرامة), meaning "dignity" or "honor," has emerged as a central concept for articulating how Islamic law approaches Muslim–non-Muslim relations. Rooted in the Qur'an and developed through centuries of juristic reasoning, karāmah offers a theological and legal foundation for coexistence that predates—and in many ways parallels—modern human rights discourse.

The Qur'anic Foundation

The principle of karāmah is most often traced to the Qur'anic verse: "*We have certainly honored (karramnā) the children of Adam*" (Qur'an 17:70). The verb *karrama* in this verse is significant for several reasons:

- It is universal in scope, addressing **banī Ādam** (the children of Adam), not a specific religious community.
- It establishes dignity as an **intrinsic** quality bestowed by divine decree, not earned through belief or behavior.
- It precedes legal categorizations such as Muslim, *dhimmī* (protected non-Muslim), or *musta'min* (a non-Muslim under temporary safe-conduct).

Other foundational verses reinforce this framework, including Qur'an 49:13, which presents human diversity as a divine intention for mutual recognition (*li-ta'ārafū*), and Qur'an 2:256, which prohibits compulsion in religion (*lā ikrāha fī al-dīn*). Together, these verses form a Qur'anic anthropology in which human dignity is prior to confessional identity.

Historical Contexts: From Madinah to the Caliphates

The practical application of karāmah can be traced to the **Constitution of Madinah** (*Ṣaḥīfat al-Madīnah*), an early 7th-century document that organized relations between the Muslim community and Jewish tribes of the city. The document recognized non-Muslims as part of a single political community (*ummah wāḥidah*) with mutual obligations of defense and non-aggression.

Under the Rashidun, Umayyad, Abbasid, Andalusian, Ottoman, and Mughal polities, the legal category of **ahl al-dhimmah** (protected peoples) institutionalized a contract under which non-Muslims paid the *jizyah* tax in exchange for protection, internal autonomy in personal status law, and freedom of worship. While modern critics rightly note that *dhimmī* status involved hierarchical distinctions, historians also acknowledge that, in its time, the framework provided a degree of legal stability for religious minorities that was uncommon in the pre-modern world.

Karāmah in the Juristic Schools

The four major **Sunni madhāhib**—Ḥanafī, Mālikī, Shāfiʿī, and Ḥanbalī—each engaged the concept of human dignity, though with different emphases:

- **Ḥanafī**: Often considered the most expansive in extending civic protections to non-Muslims. Abū Ḥanifa famously argued that the inviolability of life (*ishmah*) is grounded in *ādamiyyah* (humanness) itself, not in Islamic belief. This position influenced the legal codes of the Ottoman Empire and Mughal India.
- **Mālikī**: Rooted in the practice of Madinah, Mālikī jurists emphasized communal coexistence and recognized customary arrangements (*ʿurf*) with non-Muslim populations, particularly in North Africa and al-Andalus.
- **Shāfiʿī**: Tended toward a more textually formalist approach but maintained robust protections for *dhimmi* contracts, treating their violation as a serious breach.
- **Ḥanbalī**: Often perceived as more restrictive, yet figures such as Ibn Taymiyyah articulated the principle that *justice* (*ʿadl*) is owed even to non-Muslims, famously stating that God upholds the just state even if it is unbelieving, and brings down the unjust state even if it is Muslim.

Shīʿī schools (Jaʿfarī, Zaydī, Ismāʿīlī) developed parallel frameworks, also grounding non-Muslim protections in scriptural and rational principles.

Theological Schools and Their Frameworks

Islamic theological traditions—**Ashʿarī**, **Māturīdī**, and **Muʿtazilī**—approached karāmah through different epistemological lenses:

- The **Muʿtazilites** emphasized rational moral realism, arguing that human dignity and justice are discernible through reason independent of revelation.
- The **Māturīdīs**, dominant among Ḥanafīs, held a moderate position affirming both reason and revelation as sources of ethical knowledge.
- The **Ashʿarīs** grounded dignity more strictly in revelation but did not dispute its universality.

These theological positions shaped how jurists interpreted the scope of karāmah—whether it extended robustly to all humans by reason or required scriptural specification.

Minority and Majority Settings

The application of karāmah varies significantly depending on whether Muslims live as a majority or minority:

- In **majority settings**, classical fiqh assigned the state responsibility for protecting non-Muslim life, property, places of worship, and personal status law.
- In **minority settings**, the jurisprudence of *fiqh al-aqalliyyāt* (jurisprudence of minorities), developed by contemporary scholars such as Taha Jabir al-Alwani and Yusuf al-Qaradawi, emphasizes civic engagement, respect for constitutional orders, and contractual obligations (*uqūd*) toward non-Muslim societies.

In both contexts, *karāmah* operates as a baseline ethical commitment: the dignity of the other is not contingent on demographic power.

Orientalist Perspectives

Western scholarship on Islamic law has historically oscillated between two poles. Earlier **Orientalists** such as Ignaz Goldziher and Joseph Schacht offered influential—if sometimes reductive—readings of Islamic legal history, occasionally framing *dhimmī* arrangements primarily through the lens of subordination. More recent scholarship, including the work of Wael Hallaq, Anver Emon, and Khaled Abou El Fadl, has nuanced these readings by examining how pre-modern Islamic legal pluralism actually functioned and how *karāmah*-based reasoning operated within it.

This corrective scholarship neither romanticizes the past nor dismisses it; it situates Islamic legal practice within its historical conditions while identifying internal resources for contemporary ethical reasoning.

Karāmah and the Universal Declaration of Human Rights

The **Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR)**, adopted by the United Nations in 1948, opens with the affirmation that "all human beings are born free and equal in dignity and rights." Many Muslim scholars have noted a striking conceptual resonance with Qur'an 17:70.

Subsequent documents, such as the **Cairo Declaration on Human Rights in Islam** (1990) and the more recent **Document on Human Fraternity** (2019, signed in Abu Dhabi), explicitly invoke human dignity as a shared ethical principle. While debates persist over the compatibility of specific provisions, the *karāmah* principle provides a substantive Islamic vocabulary for engaging international human rights norms—not as a foreign imposition but as a translatable ethical commitment.

A Humanistic Reading of Sharia

A humanistic approach to sharia—advanced by scholars such as Mohammad Hashim Kamali, Abdullahi An-Na'im, and Tariq Ramadan—centers *karāmah* and the **maqāṣid al-sharī'ah** (higher objectives of Islamic law). The classical *maqāṣid* include the preservation of life (*ḥifẓ al-nafs*), religion (*ḥifẓ al-dīn*), intellect (*ḥifẓ al-'aql*), lineage (*ḥifẓ al-nasl*), and property (*ḥifẓ al-māl*). Contemporary scholars increasingly add **dignity** and **freedom** as explicit objectives.

From this perspective, interfaith coexistence is not a concession to modernity but a structural feature of sharia itself, when sharia is read through its own foundational objectives rather than through isolated rulings detached from context.

Conclusion

Karāmah offers a coherent Islamic foundation for interfaith coexistence: scripturally grounded, historically practiced, juristically developed, and ethically resonant with contemporary human rights discourse. Recognizing dignity as intrinsic to every human being—Muslim or not—transforms coexistence from a

pragmatic compromise into a theological commitment. In an era of religious polarization, retrieving karāmah from within the Islamic tradition provides both Muslims and their interlocutors with a shared ethical horizon.